

Japan, *February 2027*

Three weeks across Tokyo, the mountains, Kyoto's old streets, and a snow week in Nozawa. Nine of us, three generations, one big birthday.

DATES

2 — 25 Feb

NIGHTS

23

OF US

9

The crew

Dad

The 70-year-old

Mum

Gray

Sophie

Jess

Ben

Florence

9

Juniper

6

Goldie

2

The shape of the trip

Land late, ease in. A buffer for jetlag, body clocks, and the toddler. Big-city anchor experiences before we head into the mountains.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

MIMARU Tokyo Asakusa Station — apt-hotel, family suites with full kitchens, lift access. 3 min walk to Asakusa Station. [Property →](#) TBC

- Tue 2 TRAVEL Brisbane → Tokyo Narita, lands **17:30**. Transfer to hotel (~90 min). Conbini / hotel dinner — likely settled by 21:00.
- Wed 3 ANCHOR Morning: [Kappabashi-dori](#) kitchen town (knives, ceramics, plastic food samples). Afternoon: [Setsubun](#) at [Sensō-ji](#) — bean-throwing festival, oni costumes.
- Thu 4 ANCHOR Morning: [Tsukiji Outer Market](#) — sashimi breakfast, market wander. Afternoon: [Hama-rikyu Gardens](#) + tea house on the pond island. **Gray + Sophie evening:** [Golden Gai](#) tiny-bar crawl (Shinjuku) + whisky at [Bar Zoetrope](#).
- Fri 5 ANCHOR [Sumo morning practice](#) (6:30am, adult split-cohort, Ryōgoku). Afternoon: [depachika](#) browse (Mitsukoshi / Isetan). Early night before Hakone.

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

- STATIONERY [Itaya Ginza](#) — 13 floors of pens, washi, art supplies. Tokyo's stationery temple.
- KIDS [Pokemon Cafe + Pokemon Center DX \(Nihonbashi\)](#) — Pokemon HQ. Cafe needs ~1 month advance booking.
- CHAOS [Don Quijote \(Akihabara or Shibuya\)](#) — multi-floor discount megastore, snacks, weird stuff, tax-free.
- ARCHITECTURE [Sumida Hokusai Museum](#) — Kazuyo Sejima building + Hokusai prints. Pairs with Tsukiji morning.
- WHISKY [Bar Zoetrope \(Shinjuku\)](#) — 300+ Japanese whiskies, adult evening.
- NIGHTLIFE [Golden Gai \(Shinjuku\)](#) — six tiny alleys of 4–8 seat bars, adults only.
- HANDS-ON [Buaisou indigo workshop \(Kuramae\)](#) — traditional aizome dyeing, take a tote home.

Hakone

Sat 6 — Mon 8 Feb

Onsen town. Mt Fuji views, volcanic valleys, and the slow-down day before Kyoto.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

Hakone Ashinoko Hanaori — modern lakeside ryokan with private bookable onsens (tattoo-safe), Western-Japanese hybrid rooms (beds + chairs), lift access, family suites. [Property →](#) TBC

Sat 6

TRAVEL

Tokyo → Hakone on [Odakyu Romancecar](#) (~85 min). Lunch in Yumoto.
Afternoon: [Hakone Open-Air Museum](#). Check in to [ryokan](#), [onsen](#) + [kaiseki](#) dinner.

Sun 7

ANCHOR

[The Hakone Loop](#) — Tozan switchback railway → cable car → ropeway over [Owakudani](#) (volcanic valley, black eggs) → pirate ship across [Lake Ashi](#) (Fuji views) → [Hakone Shrine](#) (torii in the water) → bus back.

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

ART

[Pola Museum of Art](#) — Impressionists in a forest setting, walk-able from the ropeway.

PHOTOGENIC

[Hakone Glass Forest \(Venetian Glass Museum\)](#) — kid-friendly, very pretty.

The cultural heart and the depth leg. Eight nights to slow right down — temples, machiya streets, sake breweries, master craft. Wide day-trip range: Himeji, Nara, Fushimi sake, Yamazaki distillery, Osaka half-day, Kaiyukan aquarium.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

Ruikou Machiya (Machiya Residence Inn) — 4-bedroom heritage machiya, 184m², two buildings around a garden. Western beds + kitchen + dining for Mum and Dad in the detached hanare. Two kitchens.

[Property →](#) [ENQUIRY IN](#)

Backup 1: **Miyagawacho Samurai Machiya** (Gion-adjacent, 4–5 BR with multiple Western beds). [Property →](#)

Backup 2: **Tofukuji Samurai Machiya** (5 BR / sleeps 9, 2 Western beds + full kitchen, bookable now — no booking-window wait). [Property →](#)

- Mon 8 [TRAVEL](#) Hakone → Kyoto via [shinkansen](#) (~2 hr 15). Check in.
- Tue 9 [ANCHOR](#) [Higashiyama](#) / [Gion](#) day — [Kiyomizu-dera](#), Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka, [Yasaka Shrine](#), Gion wander. Optional free walking tour in the morning.
- Wed 10 [ANCHOR](#) **Fushimi day** — [Inari shrine 1000 torii](#) morning, [Fushimi sake district](#) afternoon (Gekkeikan museum + tasting, Kizakura).
- Thu 11 [ANCHOR](#) Morning: [Nara half-day](#) — [Tōdai-ji](#) giant Buddha + [deer park](#). Afternoon back in Kyoto.
- Fri 12 [ANCHOR](#) **Family:** [Himeji Castle day trip](#) (~50 min shinkansen). Keep climb + [Koko-en gardens](#). Split-cohort if Goldie skips the keep. **Gray + Sophie:** depart Kyoto for [Naoshima Island](#) (~2.5 hr), Benesse House Museum + Kusama pumpkin afternoon, overnight on island.
- Sat 13 [ANCHOR](#) Morning: **forward bags to Nozawa via** [Yamato Takkyubin](#) (arrives Sun at the lodge). **Family:** Kids day — [Toei Kyoto Studio Park](#) + [Kyoto Railway Museum](#). **Gray + Sophie:** Chichu Art Museum + Lee Ufan Museum morning on Naoshima, ferry + train back to Kyoto by evening. Family dinner together.

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

FOOD Nishiki Market — "Kyoto's kitchen," covered food street, snack as you walk.

NIGHTLIFE Pontocho alley — narrow lantern-lit alley packed with restaurants and bars after dark.

FOOD Kichi Kichi omurice — theatrical chef-as-show omurice (the famous YouTube one). Book ahead.

CALENDAR GIFT Plum blossom at Kitano Tenmangu — ~1,500 plum trees in peak bloom mid-Feb. Plum tea house in the grounds.

CULTURE Tea ceremony with a master — proper sit-down, ~90 min. Operators: Camellia, En, Hozan-ji.

KIMONO Kimono dress-up in Gion — get dressed and photographed in old Kyoto streets.

BAMBOO Arashiyama half-day — bamboo grove + Tenryū-ji + Togetsukyo bridge. Skip the monkey park.

TEMPLE Saiho-ji Moss Temple — advance postal reservation only, sutra-copying meditation, otherworldly.

LEG 04 · 5 NIGHTS — LOCKED

Nozawa Onsen

Sun 14 — Fri 19 Feb

The snow week. Skiing for those who want it, 13 free public bathhouses, and Sparena for the lower-pressure mixed-bathing option.

WHERE WE'RE STAYING

Chohachisou Lodge — whole second floor exclusive to the group. Each family unit has their own room. Mum + Dad's room has an ensuite. Walking distance to lifts and the village. **CONFIRMED**

Sun 14 **TRAVEL** Kyoto → Tokyo → Iiyama → Nozawa (~5 hr door-to-door). Daypacks only — bags arrived ahead via takkyubin. **9am Kyoto → ~2:30pm Nozawa**. Check in at Chohachisou Lodge, onsen, settle.

Mon 15 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 1**. Skiers on the mountain (girls with parents/uncles). Non-skiers: village + Sparena + Sakaya Honten sake.

Tue 16 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 2**. Non-skiers optional Nagano + Obuse day-trip (Zenkō-ji, Hokusai Museum, Masuichi-Ichimura sake).

Wed 17 **ANCHOR** **Ski day 3**. Non-skiers: village + onsen + relaxed pace.

Thu 18 **FREE** **Chill day**. Onsen, Sparena, slow village wander, pack. Everyone wind-down.

Back to the city for the wind-down. The sushi-counter dinner. The slow re-pack.

WHERE WE COULD STAY

MIMARU Tokyo Asakusa Station (same as arrival) — apt-hotel, family suites with full kitchens, lift access. 3 min walk to Asakusa Station. [Property →](#) TBC

Alternate: **MIMARU Tokyo Shinjuku West** (swap neighbourhood for the wind-down). [Property →](#)

- Fri 19 TRAVEL Nozawa → Tokyo (~2.5–3 hr door-to-door). 9am Nozawa → ~12:30pm Tokyo. Daypacks only — bags forwarded Thu.
- Sat 20 FREE Wind-down from snow — slow Tokyo wander, depachika lunch, easy day. Candidate window for Hiroshima sub-cohort overnight (TBC with family).
- Sun 21 FREE Free — Tokyo neighbourhood walk or Hiroshima sub-cohort returns. **Gray + Sophie evening:** karaoke box night (Big Echo / Karaoke-kan / Pasela in Shinjuku or Shibuya).
- Mon 22 ANCHOR **Dad's golf day** — [Ginza](#) morning ([Honma](#) + [Mizuno](#) flagships), Kanda Ogawamachi afternoon ([Victoria Golf](#) + sports street browse).
- Tue 23 ANCHOR Morning: [Ghibli Museum](#) (Mitaka — book tickets 10am JST on 10 Jan 2027). Evening: **Dad's birthday dinner** — sushi counter.
- Wed 24 ANCHOR [teamLab Planets](#) (Toyosu — barefoot water immersive) + [Small Worlds Tokyo](#) (Ariake — model city park, get inserted as figurines).

BONUS — IF YOU'VE GOT TIME

VIEW [Shibuya Sky](#) — 230m glass-edged open-air observation deck. Sunset is the play.

STATIONERY [Kakimori \(Kuramae\)](#) — make-your-own notebook + custom ink at Inkstand next door. Reddit favourite.

ART [Yayoi Kusama Museum](#) — Kusama deep dive. Lottery booking opens 2 months ahead.

DESIGN [21_21 Design Sight \(Tadao Ando, Midtown\)](#) — rotating design exhibitions.

WALK [Yanaka old-town](#) — quiet residential Tokyo, narrow lanes, less touristy.

SUB-CULTURE [Nakano Broadway](#) — multi-floor anime/manga/used goods. Mandarake flagship inside.

BEER [Yebisu Beer Museum](#) — small museum + tasting bar, dad-coded half-day.

Where we're at

LOCKED IN

Flights (Brisbane → Narita, 2 Feb 17:30)

Nozawa dates 14–19 Feb — Chohachisou Lodge confirmed

5-leg itinerary shape

Itinerary shared with family group

OPEN THREADS

Accommodation for Tokyo / Hakone / Kyoto

Ghibli tickets (10 Jan 2027 release)

Sushi counter for birthday dinner

Hiroshima sub-cohort overnight — decide for Sat 20 / Sun 21